a career in the club scene and you only have to look at his record in competitive matches to see that it's working with England as well. Steve McClaren worked hard in those twenty minutes too. I know Sven thought a lot of him and that meant Steve was as free to get his points across as the manager. In any dressing room, a coach or a manager can't give players what they haven't got: the job is to make them find what they need inside themselves. In Shizuoka, you could have looked for a spark but you wouldn't have found one. There just wasn't anything there.

We came out for the second half with our belief and our energy drained away. It was like Sweden all over again: we sat back, couldn't keep possession and couldn't get forward. When your legs go, your head goes too. But that works the other way round as well. It was well over 100 degrees down on the field that afternoon and trying to keep your concentration fixed was like trying not to screw your eyes up in the sun: we hadn't a chance. The knock we'd taken in conceding the goal had given Brazil all the lift they needed. They came out for the rest of the game playing as if winning was just a matter of time. We'd no excuses and I don't believe there was anything we could have done differently, by way of preparation, which would have made that second half turn out any other way. Brazil just got stronger and stronger the hotter it got: we'd had the life squeezed out of us by the end of the game.

Even so, it took something very weird to beat us. There wasn't an England player who gave up, although when things happen like they did in the fiftieth minute that afternoon you do start thinking: this isn't going to be our day. Brazil won a free-kick, almost forty yards out and to the left of our penalty area. We organized to defend against a cross. From that position, you wouldn't even think of the player taking a shot.

I was standing fifteen yards away from Ronaldhino, looking straight at him. The moment he struck the ball I could see he'd shanked it: it was a cross that had gone wrong and was heading too near to the goal. It happened so slowly, as if the ball was having to force its way through the heat to get to where it was going. As I watched it arc over my head towards the far post, there was time for all the possibilities to run through my mind: *It's going behind. It's into Dave's arms. It's wide.* Finally: *This could go in here. It's not going to, surely….*

There was an eerie silence as the ball spun beyond Dave Seaman and dropped over his head but under the bar. At the time, I was certain it was a fluke. Watching it again since, I'm not so sure. Definitely there wasn't another player on the field, on either side, who'd had the faintest idea it might